

You Are the Agent

ERA MINICON 2026 · ALYSSA ADAMS · BRING THIS, OR A NAPKIN

This is not a careers worksheet. A career is one of four gauges. Everything here is adapted from *Designing Your Life* (Burnett & Evans) — a design-school heuristic with a million readers and, honestly, no controlled trial. Use it because the structure is interesting.

1 Life dashboard — where are you actually?

Fill each gauge from empty to full. Don't overthink it; the first instinct is the data.

Health

EMPTYFULL

Work

EMPTYFULL

Play

EMPTYFULL

Love

EMPTYFULL

2 Good Time Journal — five activities from last week

Real ones, with names. **Engagement and energy are different axes** — you can be completely absorbed and completely drained, and that combination is the most useful row on this page.

ACTIVITY	ENGAGEMENT 0 → 5	ENERGY -3 → +3	FLOW?

3 AEIOU — on your highest-engagement row

A

Activities — what were you *doing*?

E

Environments — where, and how did it feel?

I

Interactions — with people? systems? machines?

O

Objects — what was in play?

U

Users — who else, helping or hindering?

4 The question this whole exercise exists for

Find your lowest-energy activity. Who chose it?

An honest caveat. You just did this retrospectively, and retrospective recall of how things felt is biased — peak-end effects, mood-congruent recall, duration neglect. That is an argument for running the real version prospectively for two or three weeks. Not against the exercise.

Good Time Journal & AEIOU: *Designing Your Life* ch. 3. Official worksheets are free at designingyour.life/worksheets-and-discussion-questions. AEIOU is not a DYL invention — it is an ethnographic field-observation framework from design research (Doblin Group, c. 1991), turned around to observe yourself.

Take it home

THE PARTS THAT NEED MORE THAN SEVEN MINUTES

5 The translation drill

One sentence. No jargon. It has to survive being repeated by a hiring manager to their boss. You are not translating a *label* — you are naming a *method*.

I build / study _____
so that _____
can _____

6 Three futures — an abbreviated Odyssey Plan

Hold all three in parallel. Do not rank them. In quality-diversity terms this is an archive of elites, and keeping the archive diverse is what makes the search find the good solution.

A · What you're already doing

B · If that vanished tomorrow

Your subfield gets solved, defunded, or automated.

C · If money and other people's opinion were no object

If you only say one of these out loud, say **C**. It's the one nobody says.

7 Your compass — take an hour on these, separately

Workview (~250 words): what is work *for*? Not what job you want. What defines worthwhile work? What does money have to do with it?

Lifeview (~250 words): what is a life for? What is the relationship between you and others? What is the role of joy, sorrow, love, strife?

Then read them side by side. Where do they clash? The compass is the *coherence*, not either document alone.

8 When to pivot

Not when you're unhappy. Happiness is a noisy, slow, confounded signal.

Leave when your **rate of improvement** falls to the average rate available to you elsewhere. That's Charnov's marginal value theorem, 1976 — and note it's the *derivative*, not the level. Counterintuitively: **the richer the environment, the sooner you should leave.**

And when you go, **take your parts with you.** Across 58,000 startups, what separated eventual success from stagnation was *reuse* — the people who made it discarded less between attempts. Thrashing looks exactly like pivoting decisively.

9 If you read four things

- **Liu, Dehmamy, Chown, Giles & Wang (2021)** – hot streaks are preceded by exploration *then* exploitation. Neither half works alone. *Nature Communications* 12:5392 · doi.org/10.1038/s41467-021-25477-8
- **Lazer & Friedman (2007)** – densely connected groups converge fast on worse answers. *Admin. Science Quarterly* 52(4) · doi.org/10.2189/asqu.52.4.667
- **Casciaro, Gino & Kouchaki (2014)** – instrumental networking makes people feel dirty, and it's worse the less power you have. *ASQ* 59(4) · doi.org/10.1177/0001839214554990
- **Stanley & Lehman (2015)** – *Why Greatness Cannot Be Planned*. On serendipity, stepping stones, and why objectives deceive. Springer · doi.org/10.1007/978-3-319-15524-1

The slides, and all six simulations, are a single HTML file — open it offline and drag the sliders yourself. · Anything the room invented in the niche-construction brainstorm goes to the ISAL board.